

—BOB INGRAM—

Andy takes no bows for Hank Aaron's swing



COHEN

ANDY COHEN has heard the story before. He was credited with preserving the batting swing that led Hank Aaron to break Babe Ruth's home run record.

The story popped up again last week in the column of Dick Young of The New York Daily News.

(Thanks to George J. Byrnes of 3303 Capella avenue for a clipping of the column).

Aaron broke into baseball in 1952 with Eau Claire, Wis., in the Northern League. It was a farm club of the Milwaukee Braves.

Eddie Vellone was a third baseman for Fargo in the same league.

Vellone, now a play producer in New York City, told this story to Dick Young: "I remember one night some Braves scouts showed up to inspect their farmhands. They made remarks about how Aaron would wiggle the bat behind his ear as he waited for the pitch. They said that would have to be changed. Andy Cohen was the Eau Claire manager and he told them nothing doing, you let the kid alone.

"So, the way I look at it, Andy Cohen is responsible as anyone for the great career Aaron has had. If he had let them tamper with Aaron's style, who knows? They could have ruined him."

Denver Bears was his 'alibi'

IF ANDY needed a perfect alibi, he has one. He was not the Eau Claire manager in 1952. The record shows that he began a successful term as manager of the Denver Bears of the Western League that season.

In 1952, he was quite concerned with the Western League pennant drive which was won by his Bears who drew 461,419 fans that year.

Cohen's only association with Aaron was a one-game incident that occurred in 1960.

It was the opening home game of the season for the Philadelphia Phillies. Andy was thrust into the job of managing the Phils that day by the unexpected resignation of Eddie Sawyer.

Sawyer was the manager. He apparently saw they were going to be the futile Phils that year. He quit just before the club came home to open the season. Gene Mauck was named the manager. He didn't arrive until after the home opener. Andy, a member of the coaching staff, ran the club in its opener.

It was a most successful one. The Phillies won 5-4 in 10 innings. Andy retired with probably the best percentage in the history of baseball for a manager — 1.000.

The Phils opened at home against the Milwaukee Braves and Aaron during the game hit a home run.

Bat swing lesson from M'Graw

ANDY BELIEVES that had he been managing at Eau Claire the year Aaron broke in there he would not have changed Aaron's style even if his bat had more of a wiggle than a hula dancer.

"I learned that from John McGraw," said Andy. "Mel Ott was breaking in with the New York Giants when I was with the club.

"He had a very unorthodox swing.

"McGraw saw that Ott's peculiar stride didn't affect the young player's hitting.

"He said he was going to keep Ott with the Giants. He was afraid some minor league manager would change his batting style and ruin him if he sent him down."

Andy says he's been careful not to interfere in a good hitter's swing at the plate unless that player asks for help.

In the case of Aaron at Eau Claire, had Andy been managing the club then, he might have had to step in and try to stop Aaron's bat wiggle. That is, if he had been told by the Braves bosses to do it.

The manager of Eau Claire the year Aaron broke in was Bill Adair, who was an infielder in his playing days. So, wherever you are, Bill Adair, take a bow for helping make Hank Aaron the greatest home run hitter of all time.